of the relationship between the two countries and they broadly agreed on several issues:

a) We continue to be friends, not overtly but covertly for the time being.

b) Iran should continue to meet India's energy requirements even in the worst times.

c) We will continue to hold meetings at the government level with Shia leaders in India and a delegation should visit Iran every six months.

d) An Iranian official delegation must visit India at the earliest to normalise the relationship.

e) An Indian diplomat would be deputed to meet Rafsanjani.

In March 1986, Rafsanjani, for the first time, gave a personal audience to an Indian diplomat owing to an outstanding operation carried out by the R&AW. The diplomat informed the MEA about the meeting and passed on an assurance that an Iranian ministerial-level delegation would soon visit India. It was a historic moment when the Iranian Foreign Minister Ali Akbar Velayati visited India in August 1986 for bilateral talks. Subsequently, informal discussions were held on the sidelines of a United Nations meeting.

Interestingly, the MEA took the entire credit for the Iran operation. In Prasad's words, basically the ministry became the face of a diplomatic coup engineered by a spy agency.

'You are listening to the whole orchestra but missing the conductor/ Prasad said. 'They claimed unhindered access to the